

Public Economics and Policy
College of Population Studies
Chulalongkorn University

Gender Inequality and Gender Equality Policy in Korea

August 25, 2026

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Background

Gender Inequality in Motherhood: Italy and West Germany

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The Lowest-Low Fertility

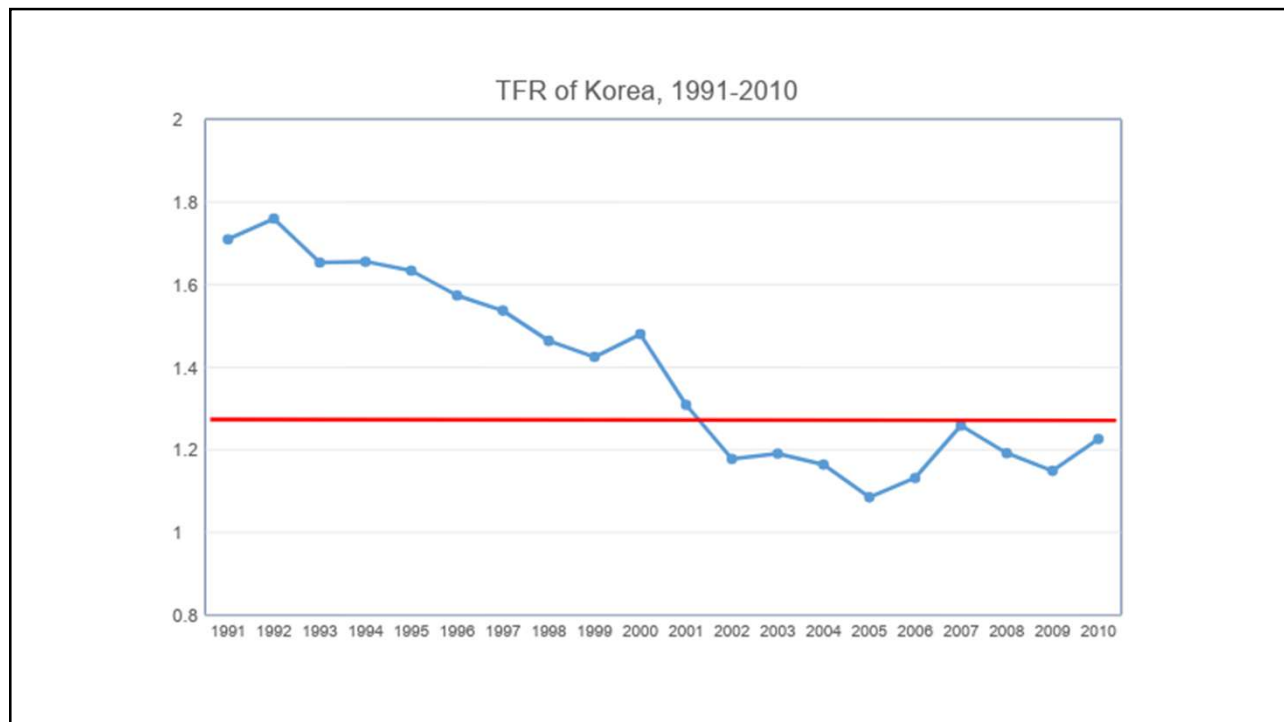
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The Lowest-Low Fertility

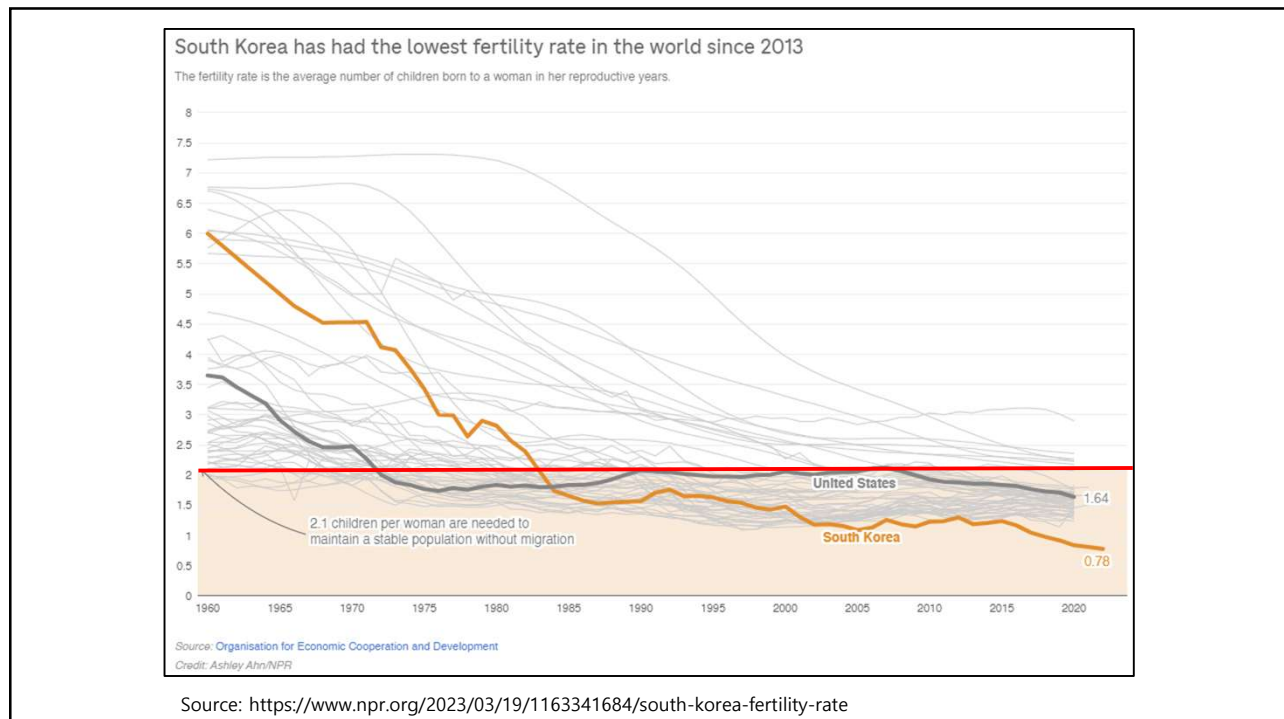
- Replacement Fertility Rate: TFR of 2.0
- Criteria of the lowest-low fertility: TFR of 1.3

(Source: Hans-Peter Kohler, Francesco C. Billari and José Antonio Ortega. 2002. "The Emergence of Lowest-Low Fertility in Europe during the 1990s" Population and Development Review, Vol. 28, No. 4, pp. 641-680.)

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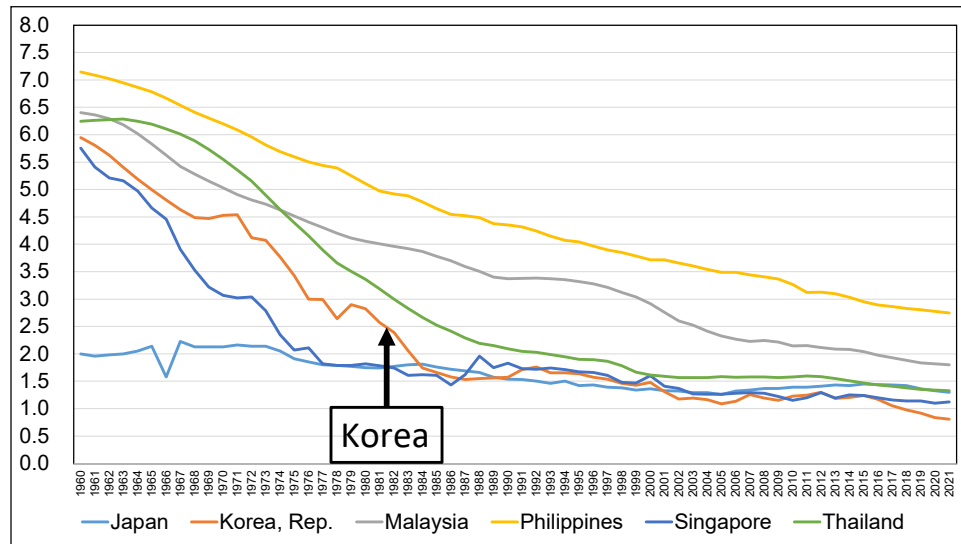


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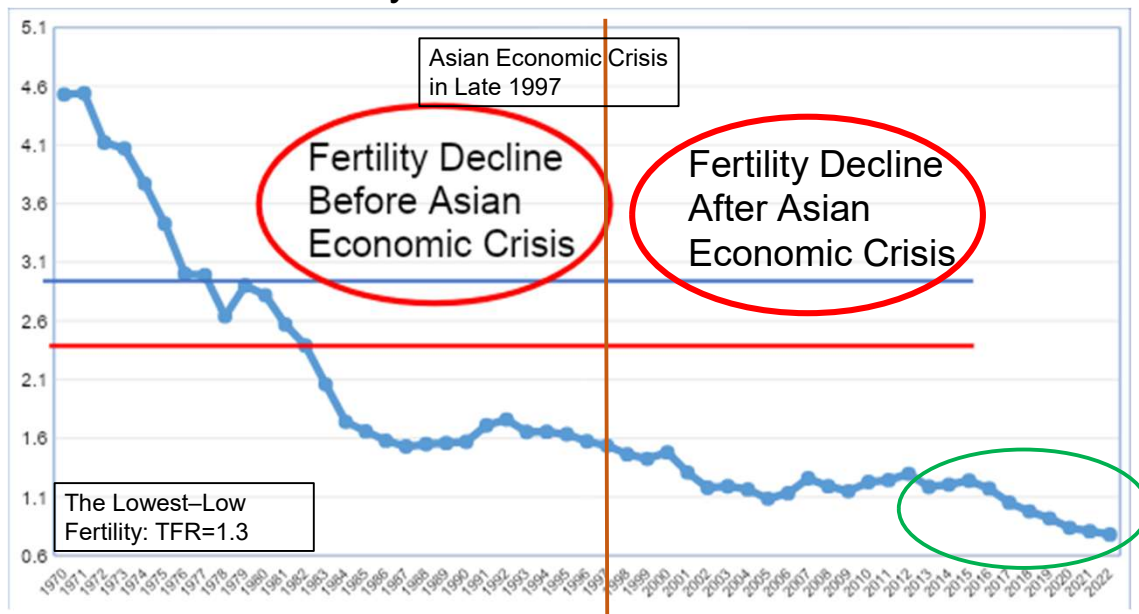
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Fertility Decline in Several Asian Countries, 1960-2021



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Total Fertility Rate in Korea, 1970-2022



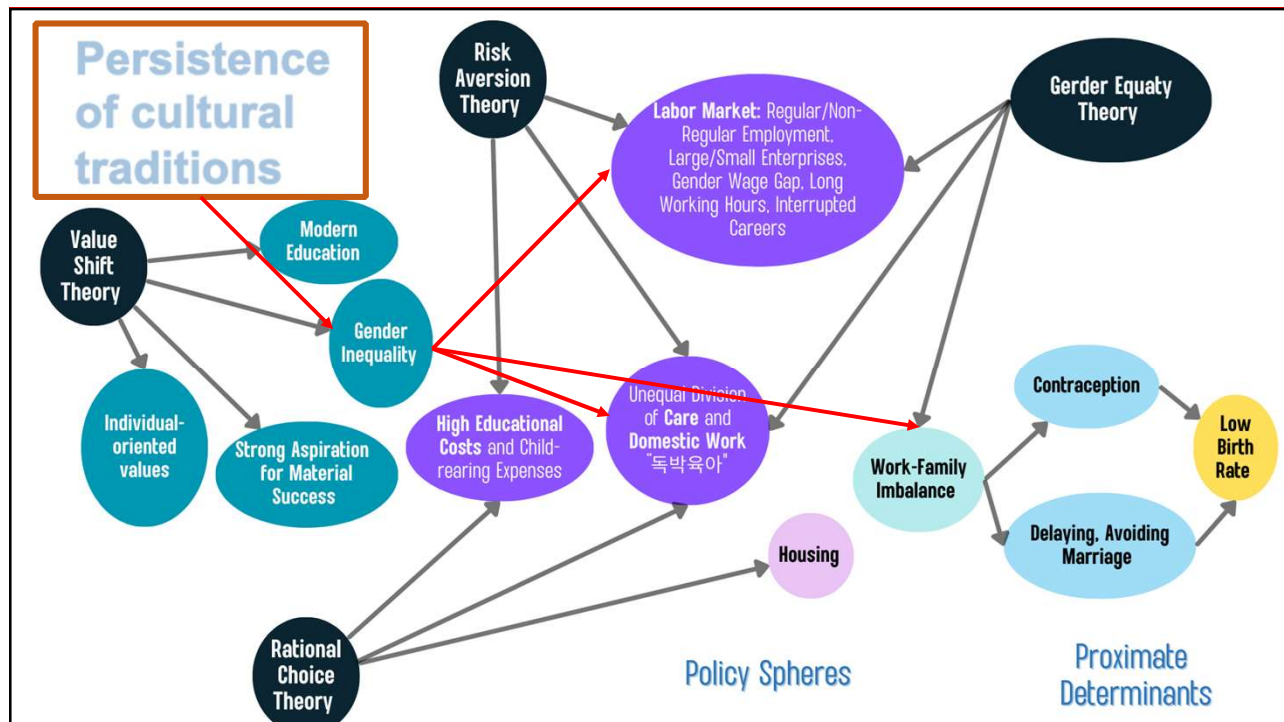
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**Fertility Crisis =
Unsustainable Society =
Threat to National Security**

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**Mechanism of the Lowest-
Low Fertility**

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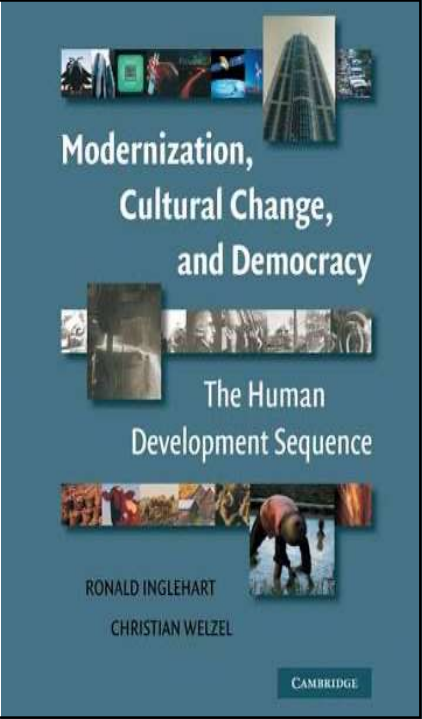
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Ronald Inglehart
University of Michigan,
Ann Arbor



Christian Welzel
International University
Bremen



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The Persistence of Traditional Cultures

Cultural Resilience:

- Traditional religious and ethnic heritages are remarkably durable and continue to shape economic and political behaviors today.

Path Dependency:

- Different societies are moving in a common direction, but they travel on parallel tracks.

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The Mechanics

The Causal Primacy of Socioeconomic Development

Existential Security:

- Economic growth and welfare systems make life highly secure. People no longer have to worry about daily survival.

Cognitive Mobilization:

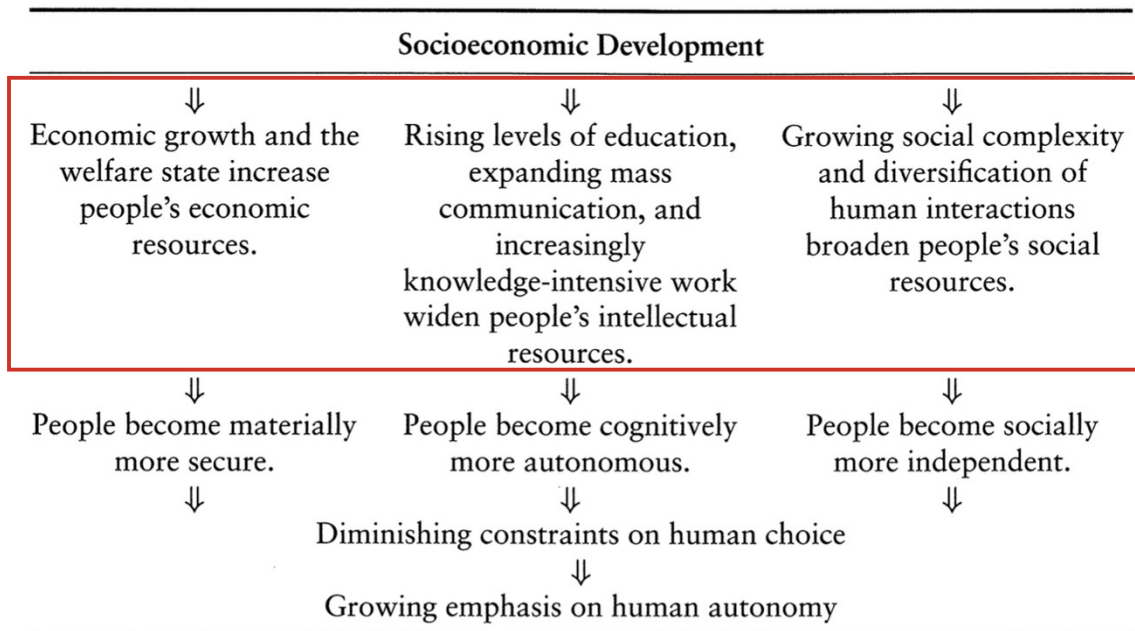
- Better education and internet access spread knowledge everywhere. This encourages people to think and decide things for themselves.

Social Complexity:

- Modern societies bring diverse human connections. Individuals can escape strict traditional groups and choose their own lifestyles.

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TABLE I.I. *The Emancipative Effects of Socioeconomic Development*

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Can We Change Values? How?

What Actually Changes Human Values?

Experiential Security

- To change people's values, they must feel safe and secure growing up. Education alone is not enough.

The Soviet Example:

In the 1990s, the Soviet economy collapsed. Even though people were highly educated, this loss of safety made them support strong, strict leaders again.

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The Backlash Against Modern Life

- Fast cultural changes can frighten some groups, especially people without jobs or with less school education.
- Feeling left behind by modern society, these groups often seek safety in strict religious rules or support radical political groups.

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Can We Change Values? How?

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2. The Backlash Against Modern Life

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How and why was Trump
elected as the US president
twice?

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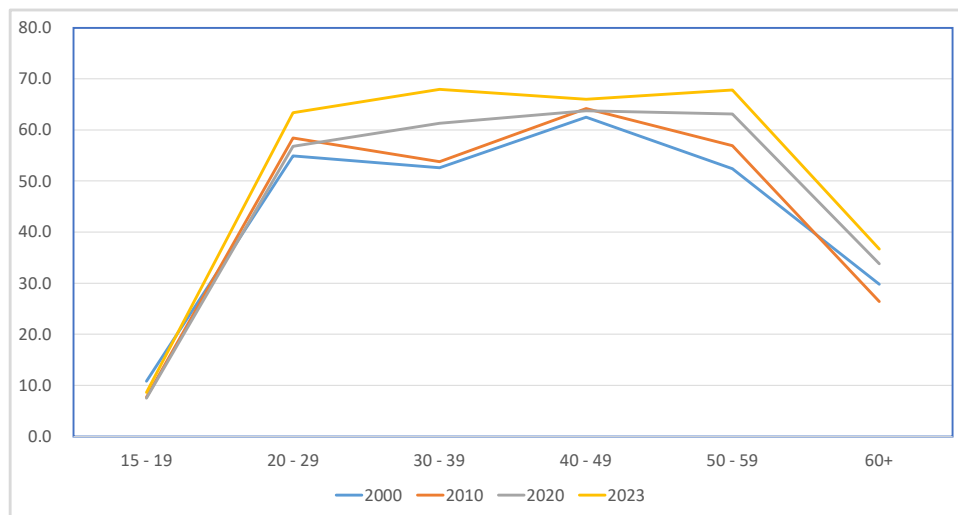
Some Aspects of Gender
Inequality in Korea

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Employment Discontinuity

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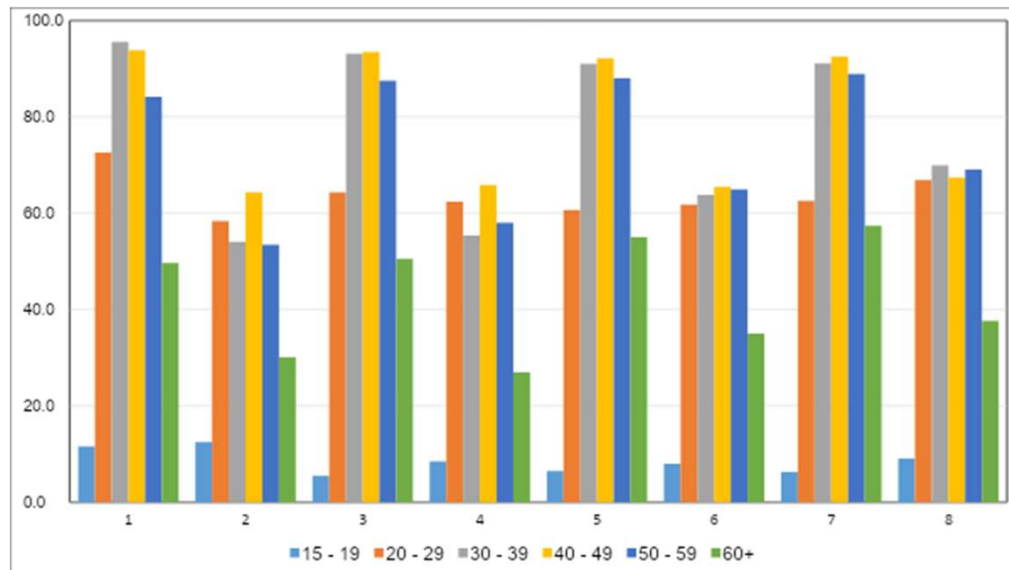
Employment Rate for Women by Age, 2000-2023



Source: KOSIS

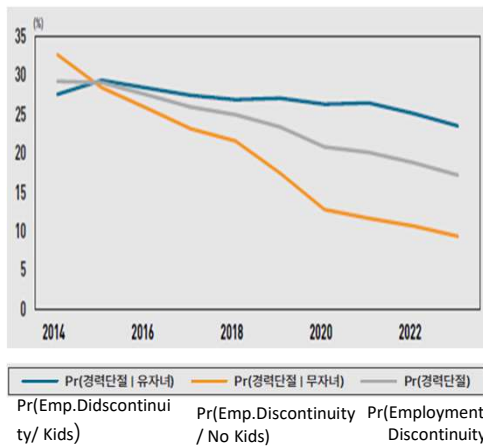
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Labor Force Participation Rate by Age and Sex, 2000-2023



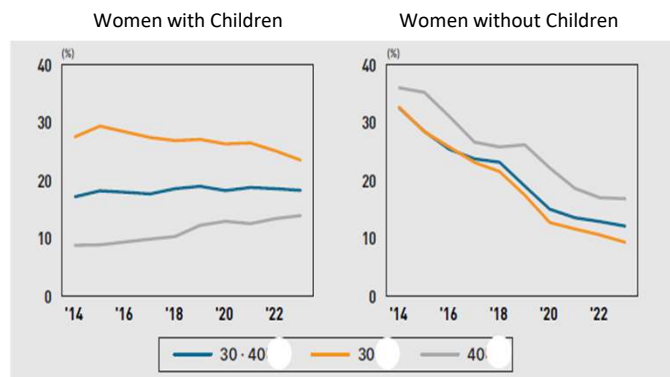
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Fig. Conditional Probability of Employment Discontinuity for Women Aged 30s by Presence of Children



Source: Cho, Duk-Sang et al. 2024. "Fear of Employment Discontinuity and Fertility Decline" KDI Focus (April 16, 2024)

Fig. Conditional Probability of Employment Discontinuity for Women Aged 30-49 by Presence of Children

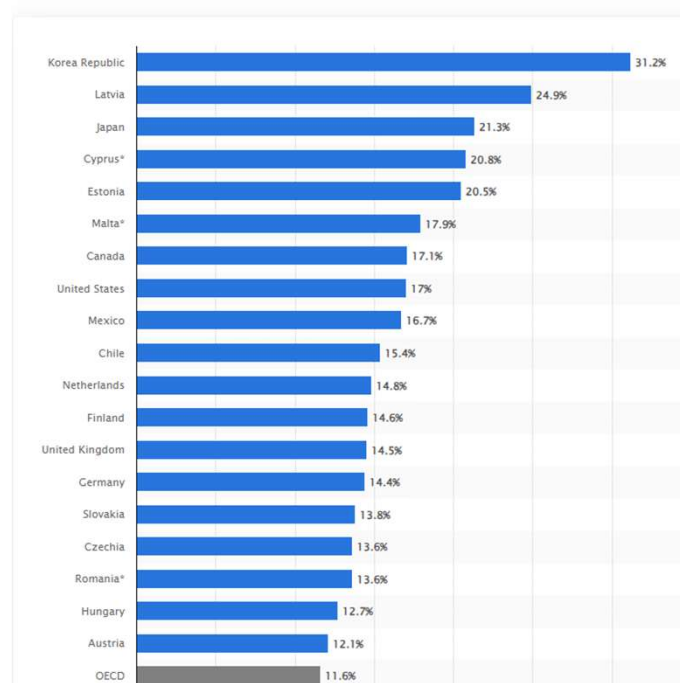


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Gender Pay Gap

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Gender pay gap in OECD countries as of 2022



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Gender Division of Unpaid Work

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Gender Division of Unpaid Work by Sex, 2019



Source: KOSIS

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Promoting Gender Equality in South Korea

Seeking Transformational Policies

[Daniel Hicks](#), [Jennifer Bouey](#), [Lynn Hu](#), [Agnes Xiangzhen Wang](#)

RESEARCH — Published Jun 2, 2025

Source: https://www.rand.org/pubs/research_reports/RRA2547-1.html

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Key Takeaways

- Gender inequity measures reveal an unequal society in South Korea in which women are often marginalized. Korean women earn 65 percent of what their male counterparts earn, the largest pay gap among Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development economies.
- The large pay gap, a lack of opportunities in the workplace, and expectations for women to be primary caregivers pressure women to withdraw from the labor force.
- Gender inequity in South Korea is rooted in a patrilineal system of inheritance, ancestor commemoration rituals, and norms that dictate hierarchical roles within the household. Gender roles have been reinforced by historical events, including economic development, military modernization, and rising tensions on the Korean Peninsula.

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- A dearth of women in high-profile positions within the Korean government and industry has left the country with few female role models.
- In the past half-century, legislative reforms and programs have been enacted to reduce disparities, including the Sexual Equality Employment Act (1987), the Mother-Child Welfare Act (1991), and the establishment of the Ministry of Gender Equality in 2001.
- While gender equality in policymaking and governance has improved, equality in labor markets and the division of labor has made slow progress.
- Options to advance gender equity include (1) taking a broader view of social inequality by, for example, combining gender equity and income inequality discussions to focus on family more broadly; (2) implementing innovative, evidence-based policies to support child care; and (3) reinforcing reforms to enhance gender equality in the workplace and the household.

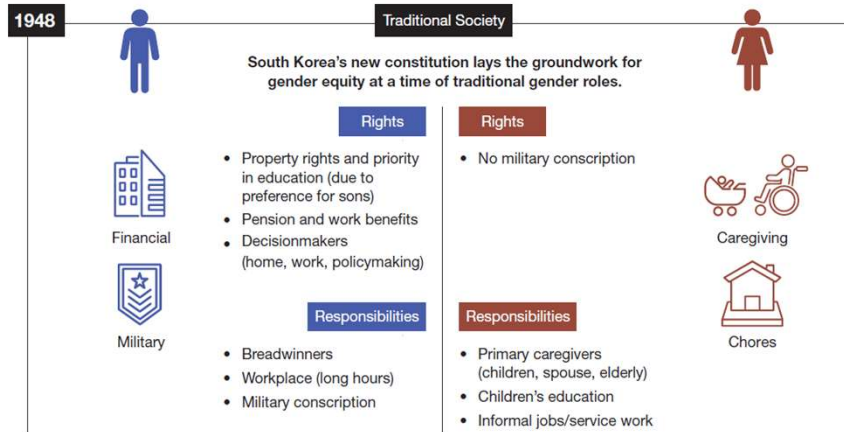
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Recommendations

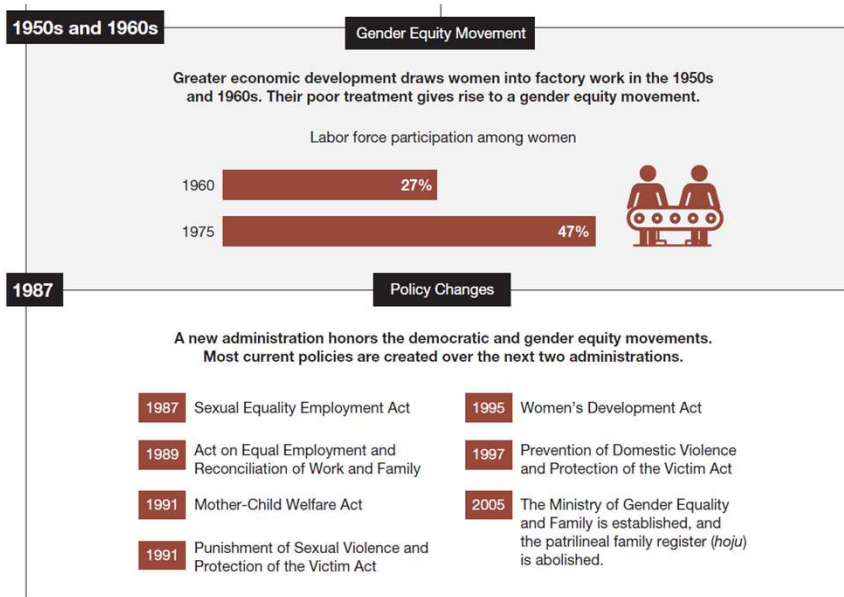
- Policymakers should take a broader view of social inequality when working to combat gender inequity. Policy efforts aimed at reducing forms of social and income inequality may prove more politically feasible and may improve gender equality by aligning the goals of broader groups of the population.
- Policymakers should implement innovative, evidence-based government policies to help families with child care and reduce education stress.
- Policymakers should reinforce reforms to enhance gender equality in the workplace and the household. Workplace and household gender ideologies often remain directly untouched in policymaking. Future policymaking should address gendered cultural norms and ideologies in both spheres, whether directly or indirectly.

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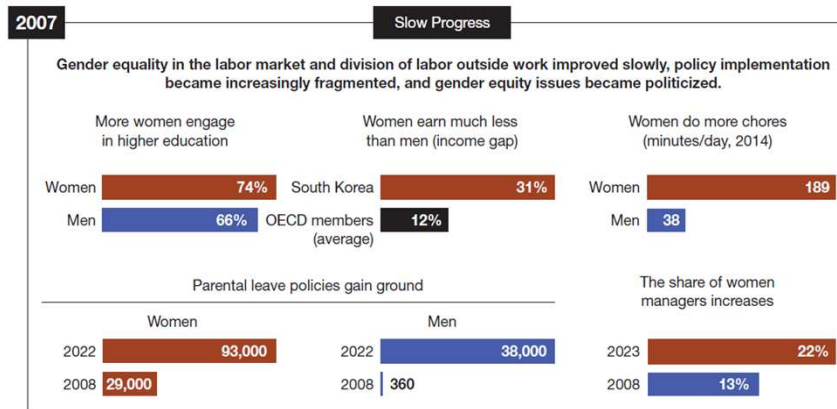
FIGURE 1
Timeline of the Changing Landscape of Gender Equity in South Korea



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2023 **At a Crossroads**

Will South Korea advance gender equity or reverse it? Here are some ways to move forward.

	Policy Solutions	
 Military conscription	Revise conscription.	
 Still breadwinners but with high housing and education costs	Combine gender equity and income inequality discussions to focus more on family, which might ease the economic pressure.	
	Support flexible work hours for parents with school-age children. Increase incentives for outsourcing household chores. Increase salary for care and household services.	 Pressure to obtain an elite education
- Difficulty adjusting to competing with women at work - Long work hours	Formalize reasonable time at work for all.	Workplace discrimination

SOURCES: This infographic summarizes background research cited in this report and in the papers produced by South Korea Gender Equity Workgroup participants. Statistics are taken from Statistics Korea, 1960; Statistics Korea, 1975; and Yang, 2021.

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Gender Equality Policies in Korea

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1. Constitution

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Constitution in Korea

Korea's Constitution, Article 11(1) prescribes, 'All citizens shall be equal before the law, and there shall be no discrimination in political, economic, social or cultural life on account of sex, religion or social status'. The Constitution prescribes equal protection of citizens regardless of their gender.

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2. Gender Equal Employment Act in 1987



Gender Equal Employment and Work-Family Balance Assistance Act in 2007

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EQUAL EMPLOYMENT OPPORTUNITY AND WORK-FAMILY BALANCE ASSISTANCE ACT

Act No. 13932, Jan. 28, 2016

CHAPTER I GENERAL PROVISIONS

Article 1 (Purpose)

The purpose of this Act is to contribute not only to realizing equal employment for both genders by guaranteeing equal opportunities and treatment in employment between men and women in accordance with the principle of equality proclaimed in the Constitution of the Republic of Korea, by protecting motherhood, and by promoting the employment of women, but also to improving the quality of all the people's lives by assisting work-family balance of workers.

[This Article Wholly Amended by Act No. 8781, Dec. 21, 2007]

Article 2 (Definitions)

The definition of terms used in this Act shall be as follows:

1. The term "discrimination" means that an employer discriminates against a worker in employment or working conditions, or takes any other disadvantageous measures without any justifiable reason, on grounds of gender, marriage, status within family, pregnancy or childbirth, etc. (including where, even if the employer equally applies employment or working conditions, the number of men or women capable of satisfying such conditions is remarkably fewer in comparison with the opposite gender, thus putting the opposite gender at a disadvantage, and the said conditions may not be attested to be justifiable): *Provided*, That this shall not apply to any of the following cases:

Source: https://elaw.klri.re.kr/eng_service/lawView.do?hseq=37613&lang=ENG

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In 1987, Gender Equal Employment Act

banned discriminations against women in hiring, wage, and retirement and so on.

In 2007, Gender Equal Employment and Work-Family Balance Assistance Act features

- Equal Opportunity in Hiring:** Employers cannot discriminate based on gender during recruitment and hiring.
- Equal Treatment at Work:** The law prohibits gender discrimination regarding wages, promotions, and retirement.
- Sexual Harassment Prevention:** Companies must conduct annual workplace sexual harassment prevention training and handle complaints properly.
- Affirmative Action:** Large companies must submit plans to improve gender balance if female employment rates fall below industry standards
- Work-Family Balance:** It supports maternity protection, childcare leave, and family care leave.

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3. Framework Act on Women's Development in 1995 (양성발전기본법)

→ Framework Act on Gender Equality in 2015 (양성평등기본법)

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The Framework Act on Gender Equality is South Korea's foundational legislation designed to promote gender equality, protect human rights, and eliminate discrimination across all areas of family, work, and society

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FRAMEWORK ACT ON GENDER EQUALITY

Act No. 16623, Nov. 26, 2019

CHAPTER I GENERAL PROVISIONS

Article 1 (Purpose)

The purpose of this Act is to realize gender equality in all areas such as politics, economy, society, and culture by providing for basic matters with regard to the obligations, etc. of the State and local governments to implement the principle of gender equality under the Constitution of the Republic of Korea.

Article 2 (Basic Principle)

The underlying principle of this Act is to achieve a *de facto* gender-equal society by rectifying and eliminating gender-discriminatory mindsets and practices based upon human dignity and respect for human rights and by sharing equal responsibilities and rights between women and men in all areas through equal participation and treatment.

Article 3 (Definitions)

The definitions of terms used in this Act shall be as follows:

1. The term "gender equality" means a state that ensures the equal enjoyment of human rights and equal participation and treatment in all areas, without any gender-based discrimination, prejudice, depreciation, or violence;

Source: https://elaw.klri.re.kr/eng_service/lawView.do?hseq=52893&lang=ENG

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CHAPTER II MASTER PLANS FOR GENDER EQUALITY POLICIES AND SYSTEM FOR PROMOTION THEREOF

Section 1 Formulation, etc., of Master Plans for Gender Equality Policies

Article 7 (Formulation of Master Plans for Gender Equality Policies)

(1) The Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall formulate a master plan for gender equality policies (hereinafter referred to as "master plan") every five years.

(2) Each master plan shall include the following:

1. Basic objectives and directions of gender equality policies;
2. Tasks and methods to pursue gender equality policies;
3. Methods for securing and managing financial resources for promoting gender equality policies;
4. Other matters prescribed by Presidential Decree as necessary for gender equality policies.

(3) In formulating a master plan, the Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall have prior consult with the heads of the relevant central administrative agencies.

(4) In formulating a master plan, the Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall utilize the national gender equality index developed under Article 19. <Added by Act No. 13369, Jun. 22, 2015>

(5) A master plan shall be finalized after deliberation by the Gender Equality Committee established under Article 11. The Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall notify the finalized master plan to the heads of the relevant central administrative agencies, the Special Metropolitan City Mayor, Metropolitan City Mayors, Special Self-Governing City Mayors, Do Governors, and Special Self-Governing Province Governors (hereinafter referred to as "Mayors/Do Governors"). <Amended by Act No. 13369, Jun. 22, 2015>

(6) Other matters necessary for formulating, modifying, etc., a master plan shall be prescribed by Presidential Decree. <Amended by Act No. 13369, Jun. 22, 2015>

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Article 8 (Formulation of Annual Action Plan)

- (1) The heads of central administrative agencies and Mayors/Do Governors shall respectively formulate and implement annual action plans according to the master plan (hereinafter referred to as "action plans").
- (2) Each year, the heads of central administrative agencies and Mayors/Do Governors shall respectively submit action plans for the relevant year and the results of implementation for the previous year to the Minister of Gender Equality and Family, as prescribed by Presidential Decree, and the Minister of Gender Equality and Family may request the heads of central administrative agencies and Mayors/Do Governors to adjust their action plan after examining the action plan submitted.
- (3) The Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall comprehensively evaluate the results of implementation received under paragraph (2). In such cases, the Minister of Gender Equality and Family may request a professional agency to conduct examinations, analysis, etc., necessary for the evaluation.
- (4) Other matters necessary for formulating and implementing an action plan, evaluating implementation results, etc., shall be prescribed by Presidential Decree.

Article 9 (Cooperation in Developing and Implementing Plans)

- (1) If necessary, the Minister of Gender Equality and Family may request the heads of relevant central administrative agencies, local governments or public institutions to cooperate in formulating and implementing a master plan and action plan.
- (2) If necessary for formulating and implementing action plans, the heads of central administrative agencies and Mayors/Do Governors may request cooperation from the heads of the relevant central administrative agencies, local governments and public institutions, non-profit corporations, non-profit civil organizations, relevant professionals, etc.
- (3) Any person in receipt of a request for cooperation under paragraph (1) shall cooperate therewith except in extenuating circumstances.

Article 10 (Fact-Finding Survey on Gender Equality, etc.)

- (1) For formulating, etc., a master plan, the Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall conduct a fact-finding survey on gender equality every five years and may publish the findings thereof.
- (2) Necessary matters relating to the content, methods, etc., of a fact-finding survey on gender equality under paragraph (1) shall be prescribed by Presidential Decree.
- (3) The Minister of Gender Equality and Family shall take necessary measures to ensure that citizens make easier access to the information on gender equality and make daily use thereof.

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The Framework Act on Gender Equality

Key Principles and Obligations

- **Citizen Rights:** Every citizen holds the right to receive gender-equal treatment and lead a gender-equal life in all societal domains.
- **State Duties:** The state and local governments must establish legal and institutional frameworks, secure adequate financial budgets, and guarantee maternal and paternal rights without discrimination.
- **Master Plans:** The [Ministry of Gender Equality and Family](#) must create a comprehensive five-year master plan outlining policy objectives, execution tasks, and resource management.

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「Announcement of the third basic plan for gender equality policy[2023~2027]」 and national gender equality index (NGEI)

Ministry of Gender Equality & Family
Jan 30, 2023

Source: <https://www.korea.net/Government/Briefing-Room/Press-Releases/view?articleId=709072&type=N&insttCode=A260114>

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The third basic plan for gender equality policy (2023~2027) set "a society that upholds gender equality and where everyone is happy" as its **vision** and the following **three objectives**: 1. "fostering an environment where all work together and care for children together"; 2. "promotion of safety and right to health"; and 3. "expansion of basis for gender equality."

The third plan, which has been set up with the policy environment and people's demand reflected, adopts **the following main tasks**:

1. Fostering a working environment with fairness and gender equality;
2. Establishment of a childcare safety network for all;
3. Provision of support for violence victims and guarantee of gender awareness-based right to health;
4. Dissemination of win-win gender equality culture;
5. Strengthening of basis of gender equality policy.

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[Task 1] Fostering a working environment with fairness and gender equality

- Promotion of **a system of businesses' voluntary public disclosure of gender ratio status of employees** in factors like employment, work, retirement, etc.
Invigoration of women's participation in economic activities by **strengthening services designed to prevent women experiencing career interruption and expand their future job opportunities.**
- Review of how to rearrange the current childcare temporary retirement system in relation to the expansion of those eligible for employment insurance; promotion of **expansion of childcare temporary retirement period (from one year to one and a half years)** for the sharing of childcare burden between man and wife.
- Striving to recognize **the right of employees to reduce their work hours voluntarily** to spend more time for childcare or care of sick family members; Support for the **expansion of family-friendly workplace culture** through the designation of exemplary businesses.
* Designation of exemplary businesses in family-friendliness: for 15 years in the case of large-sized businesses(4 times of certification); for 12 years in the case of SMEs(3 times of certification)
- **Encouraging the invigoration of work at home and teleworking at SMEs**; inclusion of **support for work-life balance for subcontractors** in the appraisal of large-sized businesses concerning accompanied growth.

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[Task 2] Establishment of childcare safety network for all

- Expansion of support for non-homeroom teachers at childcare centers and extracurricular activity hours **for more efficient all-day childcare services for infants.**
- Diversifying extracurricular activity programs and increasing the number of those taking part to **eliminate blind spots in childcare for elementary schoolers***; adoption of elementary neul-bom (warm like spring) school (phased extension of hours up to 8:00 pm)
* Percentage of elementary schoolers taking part ('22) 45.1% → ('25)60%; number of relevant programs adopted at elementary schools: ('22) 172,644 → ('25) 200,000
- Increasing the hours of government support for childcare service and number of households receiving the **support provided to working couples or the like requiring childcare aid**; increasing the number of joint childcare centers.
- **Strengthening support for those who should raise children** such as single parents, young parents, foster homes, servicemen, etc. **Strengthening the infrastructure for official adult care(e.g.,seniors, the disabled, those with severe disability)** including expansion of integrated nursing service, enhancement of service quality, and support for those with development disabilities. Provision of **support for repairing problematic relationships like family conflict** through local family centers; Provision of customized programs per lifecycle to **prevent the isolation of one-person households or the like.**
- Strengthening the supervision of childcare workplaces and **improving the working conditions of their employees**; coming up with ways to protect employees against violations of their right to work and workplace violence and those engaging in emotional labor.

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[Task 3] Provision of support for violence victims and guarantee of gender awareness-based right to health

- **Improvement of laws·systems concerning sexual violence, sexual harassment·violence in the public sector, stalking, sexual offense against children, etc.** to establish the basis for supporting victims. Strengthening the infrastructure for the protection of victims of five leading offenses (crimes perpetrated by those in power, digital sex crime, domestic violence, stalking, dating violence).
- **Making more effort to prevent secondary offense** through the provision of customized educational sessions designed to prevent violence by high-ranking officials and those at law enforcement institutions.

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[Task 4] Dissemination of win-win gender equality culture

- Holding gender equality education sessions through cross-curricular subjects to learn for the **invigoration of gender equality education**; improvement of elements related to **gender-based discrimination outside classes like** life guidance, sports activities, etc.
- Setting up a plan for the enhancement of gender representativeness in the public sector** as part of efforts to maintain balance in the participation of both genders in leading areas of the public sector*
 - * Departments in the central government, local government officials, public institutions, teachers, and those at government committees, etc.
- Carrying out the diagnosis (consulting) of organizational culture to **encourage balanced participation by both genders in the private sector**; promotion of informal sessions and visits to sites for exploration of exemplary cases or the like.
- Establishment of cooperative relationships with exemplary businesses to secure gender representativeness in decision-making organizations within businesses; Checking (monitoring) the status of their compliance with the Capital Market and Financial Investment Business Act, Article 165-20.*
 - * No stock-listed corporation whose total asset holdings is at least two trillion won shall have a board of directors made up of just one gender.(amended on 2/4/2020, enforced on 8/5/2022)

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[Task 5] Strengthening the basis of gender equality policy

- **Working to strengthen the functions of the Gender Equality Committee** by reviewing factors like addition of function of recommendation, whether follow-up measures are taken, and coming up with ways of proper management.

- **Strengthening of the system of delivering gender equality-related policies** by strengthening the functions of organizations responsible for the relevant policies in each government ministry* and invigoration of linkage of the relevant policies formulated at the central/local governments.

* Ministry of Education (MOE), Ministry of Justice (MOJ), Ministry of Defense(MOD), Ministry of Culture, Sports, and Tourism (MCST), Ministry of Health and Welfare (MOHW), Ministry of Employment and Labor (MOEL), Supreme Prosecutors' Office, National Police Agency
Faithful execution of **gender equality-related international conventions and major resolutions such as UNSC Resolution No. 1325**, etc.

- Exploration of gender equality-related policy agendas concerning Asia-Pacific through the **UN Women Centre of Excellence for Gender Equality**; invigoration of exchanges with those within the region designed to strengthen the relevant policy-related capability.

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Conclusion

- Korea is still a male-centered society.
- Achieving gender equality is an unfinished revolution in Korea.
- Gender inequality is a legacy of cultural traditions in Korea.
- Gender inequality is one of the roots of the ultra lowest-low fertility in Korea.
- We need good gender equality policies and try to make every effort to implement those policies successfully.

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